When, at the end of this year of loss, Akbar's horse stumbled during a hunt while chasing a hyena, flinging the emperor face first into stony ground, it is perhaps no wonder that Akbar's thoughts turned to his own demise: he had an epiphany that he would leave the world as empty-handed as he'd arrived.

It was only nine days previously that two great doctors of Hindustan, Narain Misra and Bhim Nath, had died. This was read as an omen: Akbar would never need doctors again. But the truth of his omens, like the health of his friends, was proving increasingly unreliable.

The emperor was pushing fifty, and while he wasn't yet old, he was certainly ageing. Akbar was marching back to Lahore when the hunting accident happened. He had spent most of the year touring Kashmir and Kabul, and refused to halt his journey now, even if he had to proceed in a litter instead of on a horse. In January 1590, the camp crossed the Indus and Akbar must have been showing signs of fatigue; Abul Fazl reports that his mother, Hamida, asked the emperor to stop and rest awhile. Rest! Akbar was a man who killed lions single-handed and cured men with his breath. He ignored his mother's fretting. Instead, the emperor decided to amuse himself upon a musth elephant.

As Akbar had khasa guns, so he had khasa elephants, 101 of them – each with at least three 'wives', and a special diet of sugar, ghee, milk and rice with chillies and cloves. The emperor himself was the mahout, and he would 'put his foot on [their] tusks, and mount them, even when they are in the rutting season, and [astonish] experienced people'.[36]

In January 1590, two years short of his fiftieth birthday, Akbar began to mount an elephant with all his usual flair – and fell down.

Never before, in the annals, had the emperor failed to control an elephant, barefooted astride its neck, with his sharp goads and his mad will; never had Akbar not overpowered his favourite animal, no matter how enraged. His fall was shocking enough to engender all kinds of rumours; violence broke out in the more faraway outposts of the realm and 'many remote parganas were plundered'.[37]

Again – as much to staunch the rumours as to assuage his pride, perhaps – Akbar did not halt. He treated himself by letting blood and marched on. Only days later, the emperor ordered an elephant parade, feeding each one